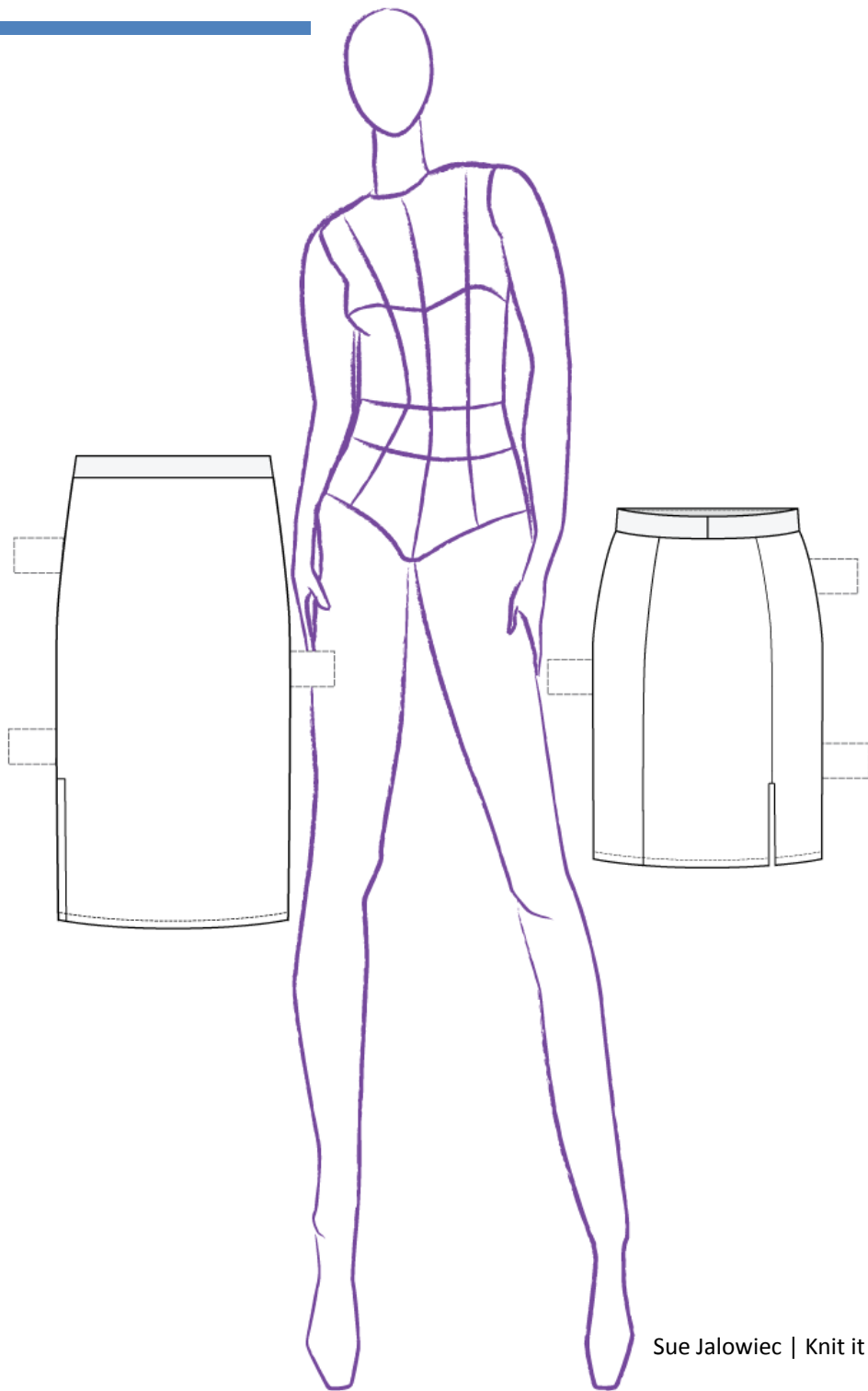

PENCIL SKIRTS

for Machine Knitters



Sue Jalowiec | Knit it Now, LLC

PENCIL SKIRTS FOR MACHINE KNITTERS

Introduction

Pencil Skirts are fashion favorites. Lengths vary from year to year, but generally fall to the knee, or just below. The slim narrow shape is made more comfortable in knitted fabric.

These skirts can be easily knit on the knitting machine. Make them simple with 2 rectangles and a gathered elastic top or high fashion with custom fit and exquisite finishing details.

This book was inspired by a knitter who requested a pattern for a pencil skirt. The first reaction: "It's just 2 rectangles!" But that wasn't what she was looking for, she wanted more details for the perfect pencil skirt to compare with those she had seen for hundreds of dollars in stores.

Pick and choose from the following techniques to turn 2 plain rectangles into a custom knit, work of art!



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Gores

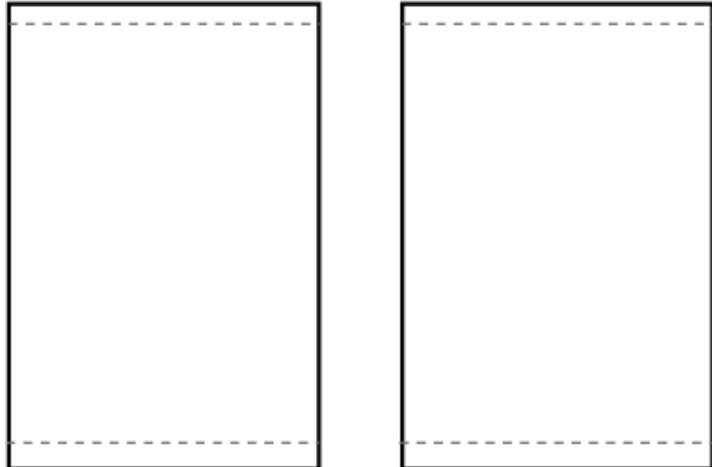
Knitting multiple gores allows you to place slits strategically for design and comfort. Knitting your skirt in multiple pieces also allows you to knit a larger size without any needle bed limitations.

2 Gore

The simplest pencil skirt is 2 rectangles. Simply calculate your pattern from your stitch and row gauge, sew up the seams, gather the top and you are done!

Get creative with stitch patterns, add a side slit or work a fancy hem. Lots of opportunities for creativity!

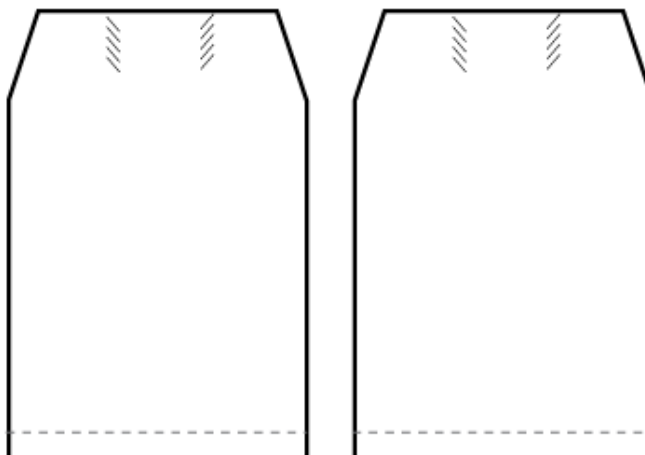
[Draft your own pattern](#)



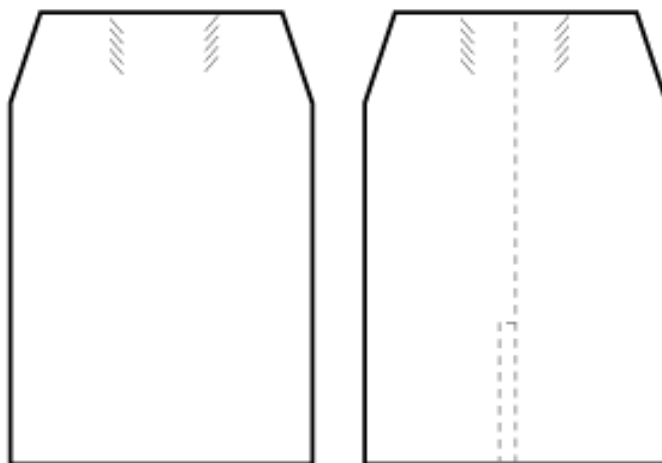
Pros:	Cons:
• Easy to draft the knitting pattern • Extra quick knitting with no shaping • Quick canvas for creativity	• Bulk at the waist

Shaped 2 Gore

For a better fit, add some shaping with vertical darts or simple side seam shaping



Pros:	Cons:
Beautiful, no-bulk fit at the waist	Working transfers for a few inches



If you add a center back seam to a 2 gore shape, you can create a slit or kick pleat in the center back seam. This attractive opening is not only a beautiful design element, it makes it easier to walk in this narrow shape.

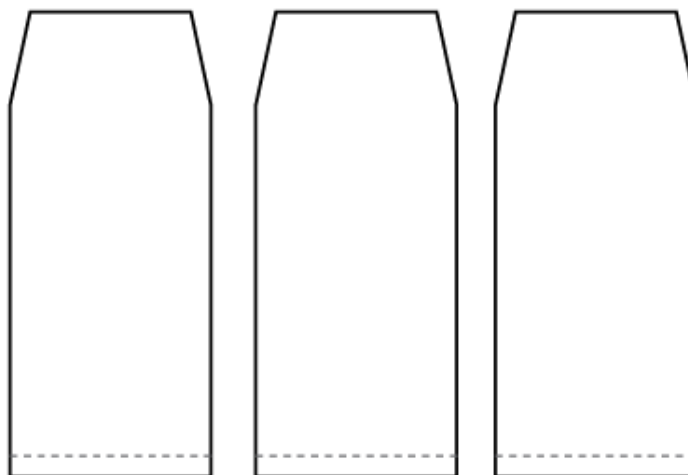
3 Gore

A 3 gore skirt can be knit with or without waist shaping.

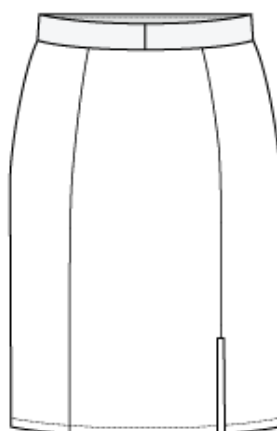
Unlike a 2 gore skirt with a center back seam, each gore is equal in width.

Wearing the skirt with a center front panel and a center back seam, allows for the slit on the side of the leg in the front of the skirt

Also, because of the limitations of the width of the needle bed, knitting 3 pieces allows for a larger size range.



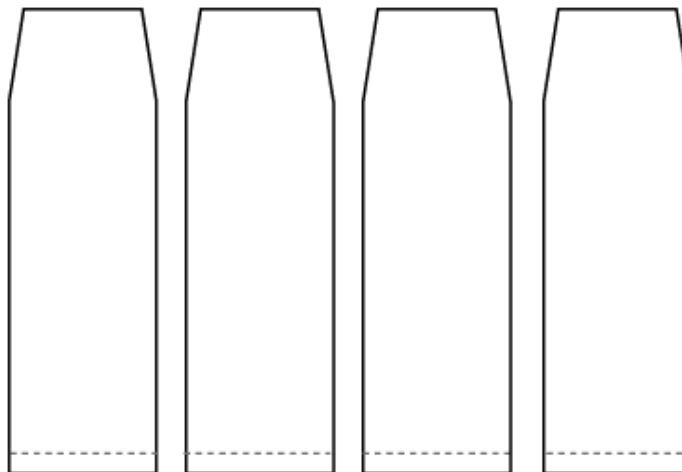
Pros:	Cons:
• Can accommodate larger sizes • Easily place a front side slit • Adds a 3rd seam to work shaping, may eliminate vertical darts for a smooth waistline	Knitting 3 pieces instead of 2



4 Gore

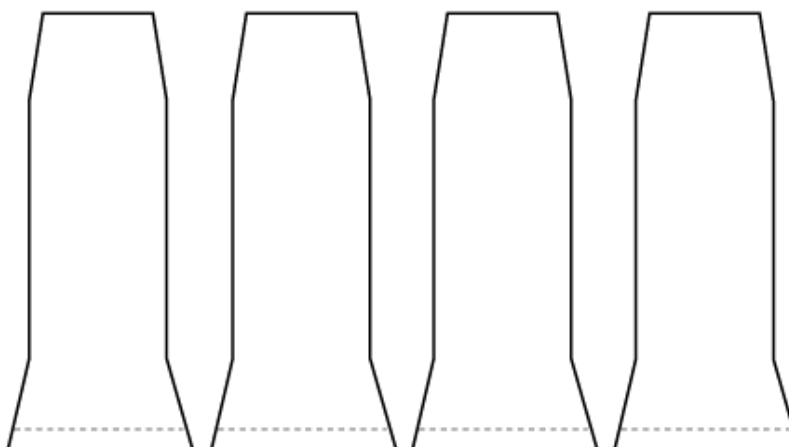
Knitting 4 gores gives you more opportunities for placement of slits. Imagine a slit on both sides of the center front panel for a dramatic fashion statement!

The extra seams may also eliminate vertical darts, putting all the shaping at the seam lines.



Pros:	Cons:
• Can accommodate larger sizes • Put slits in all for seams for a designer look • Easier shaping while knitting	• Knitting and seaming 4 pieces

4 gores can also create a completely different skirt. Add shaping at the hem for a fun, flirty tulip skirt.

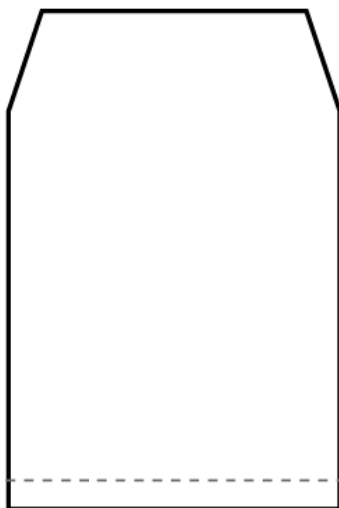


Shaping

Basic shaping

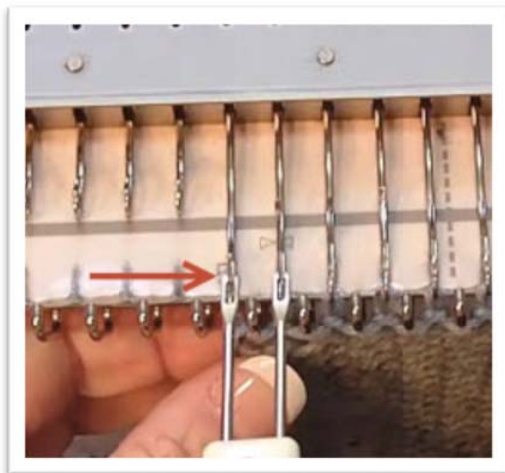
A traditional pencil skirt is figure hugging. Adding shaping to your knitting is essential for this silhouette.

Reduce the width of your knitting from your hip width to your waist size by simply working decreases as needed along the edges of the pieces.



Your knitting instructions might read: Decrease 1 stitch each side every 4th row 6 times. In vintage machine knitting patterns this instruction might read (1-4-6) (stitches, rows, times)

To add waist shaping. Use the Magic Formula, knitters graph paper, DesignaKnit or the [Knit it Now Taper Tool](#) to calculate..



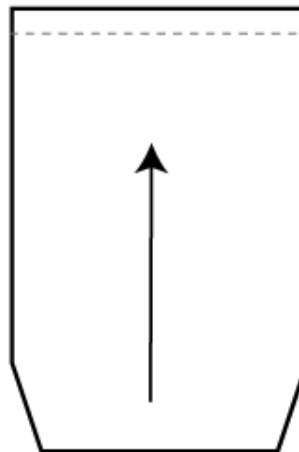
When decreasing, use a 2 prong tool to transfer the stitches. This leaves the edge stitch plain, making seaming easier.

TIP

If you choose to knit your skirt from the top down, you would **increase** from waist to hip for the shaping.

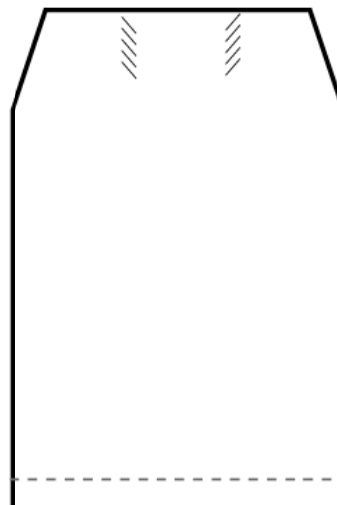
For easier seaming, work your increases 1 stitch from the edge.

Knitting the skirt from waist to hem allows you to remove the work on waste yarn, baste the pieces and try on for length. Having live stitches at the hem makes it easier to lengthen or shorten the piece without having to re-work any waste shaping



Vertical Dart shaping

You may not be able to reduce the waistband as much as needed by simply decreasing at the side seams and still maintain a smooth curve. In addition to shaping at the side seams, you may choose to use vertical (inside) darts to shape your skirt.



Work shaping within the body of your knitted piece (instead of at the edges) with vertical darts

For inside darts, it is necessary to transfer several stitches on one row. You can slowly do this with a transfer tool, or use a garter bar and transfer all the stitches at one time

A little practice with the garter bar; and it will become an easy, fast operation.

It's easier to move the stitches when you are using the garter bar if there is only one stitch on each needle.

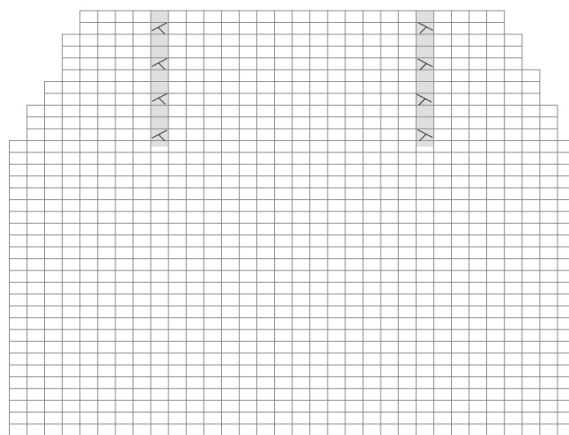
1. Transfer the decrease stitch with a 1 prong transfer tool
2. Hang a 3 prong transfer tool on the 3 needles that will not be transferring. This will help keep these stitches stable when using the garter bar.
3. Pull the **needles to be moved** into the hold position. (all the way out)
4. Place the garter bar eyes into the hooks of the needles just pulled.
5. Holding the garter bar firmly in the left hand, pull all stitches from the edge to the 3 prong tool, onto the garter bar with the right hand tugging at the fabric already knitted.
You must keep moving across in the same direction, once you have started. If you try to pull from the other side, the stitches usually will get caught in the hooks of the needles.
6. After the stitches you plan to move are on the garter bar, move the garter bar over 1 needle to fill in the emptied needle of your decrease.
7. Make sure all latches are open. Put the eyes of the garter bar on these needle hooks. Pull stitches onto these selected needles
8. Check to see that you didn't drop any stitches.
9. Take off your 3 prong tool from adjacent needles.

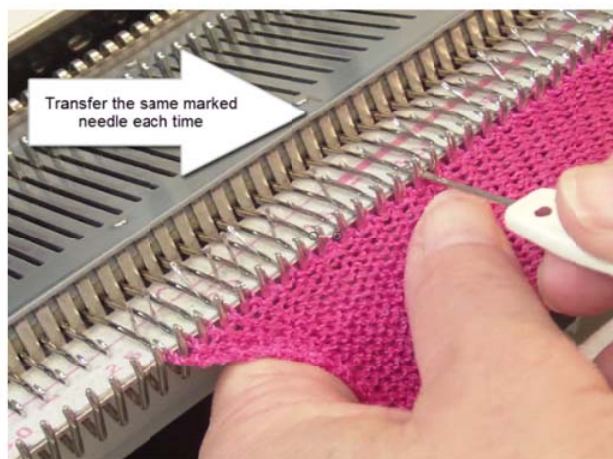
Watch this technique in action.

View the Knit it Now tutorial

["Vertical Darts"](#)

Your transfer is now complete. Repeat this for each vertical decrease according to your pattern.





Transfer the same marked needle each time

Mark the needle bed with a pencil. Transfer the same needle for your decrease each time

Hang a 3 prong tool on the needles so you don't drop stitches while transferring the group of stitches.



Work slowly and carefully for success!

Use a garter bar or any transfer tools to move the group of stitches in fill in the emptied needle, completing the vertical decrease.

No Transfer Shaping

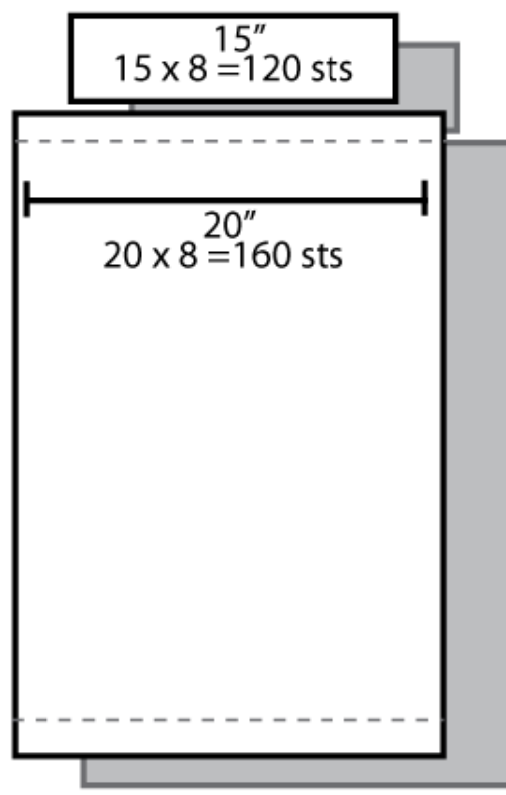
This waistband treatment adds no bulk to the waistline yet stretches easily over any size hips.

1. Start or finish your skirt waist edge with waste yarn.
2. Calculate the number of stitches needed for your waistband by multiplying your waist measurement by your stitch gauge (example 120 stitches)
3. Re-hang your skirt panel over this number of needles, doubling up stitches as needed.
4. Work the waistband of your choice. Because the band will need to stretch over your hips, be sure to use a VERY stretchy bind off

Example:

If your hips are 40 inches and your waist is 30 inches, you need to reduce ten inches totally (five inches each on the front and back)

For example, with a stitch gauge of 8 stitches per inch, you would need to reduce each panel by 40 stitches (160 sts – 120 stitches = 40 stitches)



Waistbands

Fast and Easy Waistband

Whether you knit your skirts from hem to waist or top down, easy waistbands are a simple hem.

Top Down	Hem to Waist
1. Cast on 2. Knit twice the width of your elastic 3. Hang a hem 4. Continue knitting the skirt panel 5.	1. Cast on 2. Knit the skirt panel 3. Knit a marker row 4. Knit twice the width of your elastic 5. Hang a hem 6. Bind off

Top Down (waist to hem)

1. Cast on with waste yarn and ravel cord or a simple e-wrap
2. Knit twice the width of your elastic
3. Hang a hem from the live stitches of garment yarn from the waste yarn or hang the e-wraps
4. Continue knitting the skirt panel

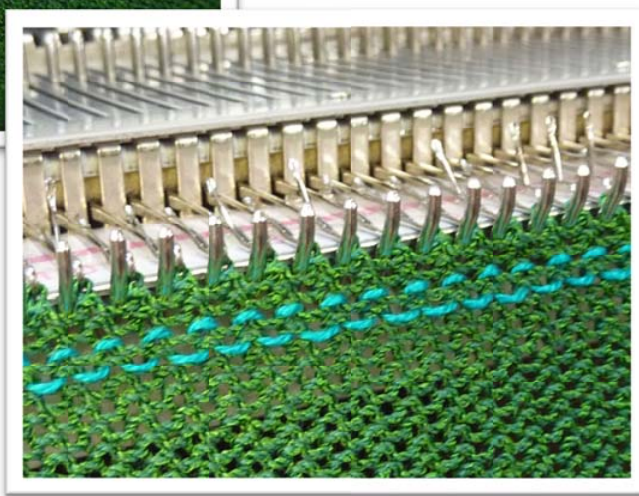
The advantage of knitting a skirt from the top down is there is no bind off edge at the waist.

Faster knitting and comfortable wear.



Hem to Waist Waistband

1. Knit your skirt panel. When you reach the waist, knit a marker row. Simply knit a contrasting thread or fine yarn with the garment yarn. You can remove the marker when your garment is complete.

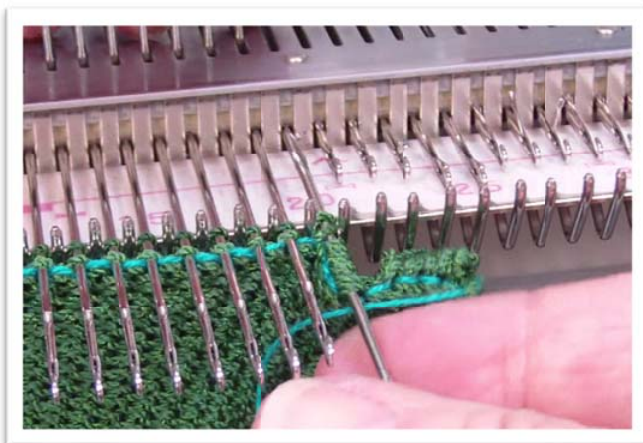
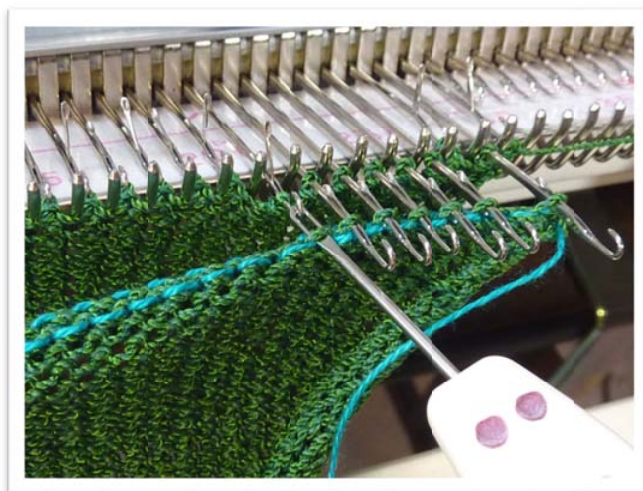


Watch this technique in action.

View the Knit it Now tutorial

["Easy Waistbands"](#)

2. Knit the waistband twice the width of your elastic.
3. Pick up the stitches from your marking row to form a casing for the elastic.
4. Bind off loosely. Don't forget this bind off needs to stretch enough to fit over your hips.

**TIP**

Instead of binding off, run a doubled strand of your garment yarn through all the stitches on the machine. This will join the waistband casing and remove the work from the machine at the same time.

Stretch the waistband as much as possible and secure the doubled strand.



On the left, the casing is was formed by running a doubled strand of yarn through all the stitches

On the right is a 'round 2 gatepage bind off.

Not familiar with this bind off?

Visit the Knit it Now Learning library and search for ["Bind Off Basics"](#)

Remove the marker thread.

Insert your elastic in the casing and gather to fit your waist.



Every Other Needle Waistband



Notice how a gathered waistband can have quite a bit of bulk.

For a smoother finish, work an every other needle waistband.

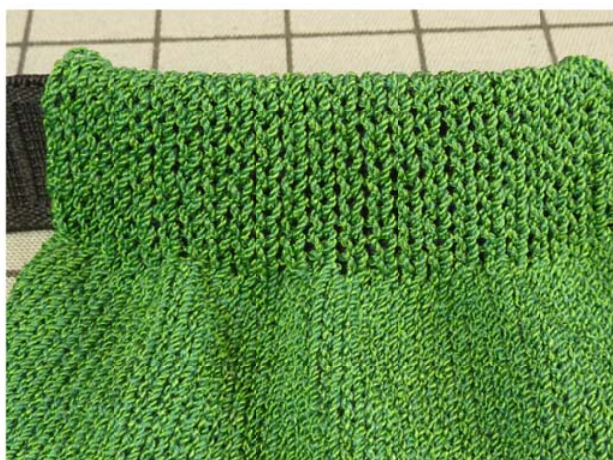
Knit the piece to the point of the waist

Transfer every other needle to the adjacent needle

Knit 2 times the width of your elastic over every other needle

Hang a casing from the last row of the body of the skirt. (the row before the transfers)

Bind off as desired and insert your elastic.



This creates a casing with half the number of stitches and much less bulk

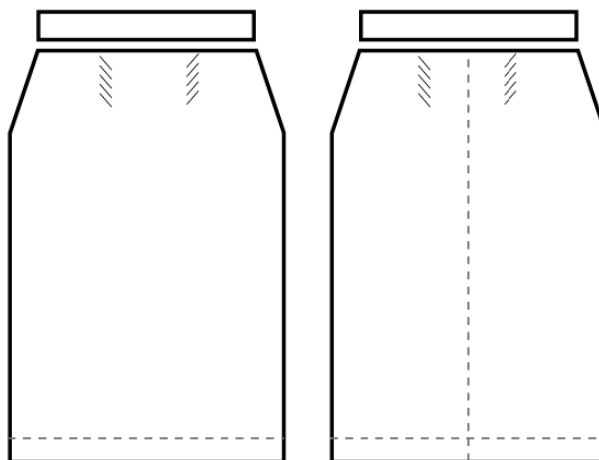
Couture Waistband

A two piece waistband is the ultimate finish for skirts. Beautiful on both the inside and the outside, it offers a lot of stretch and isn't difficult to knit!

1. End the waist edge on scrap
2. Knit ½ the waistband
3. Rehang the garment
4. Rehang the waistband
5. Knit ½ the waistband
6. Join the waistband



1. Start or end your garment on waste yarn
2. Follow your pattern or calculate the number of stitches you need for your waistband (Example 100 stitches)



With right (public) side facing, rehang the garment edge on the same number of needles as the waistband (100 stitches) doubling up stitches if needed.

This will add additional shaping to your skirt

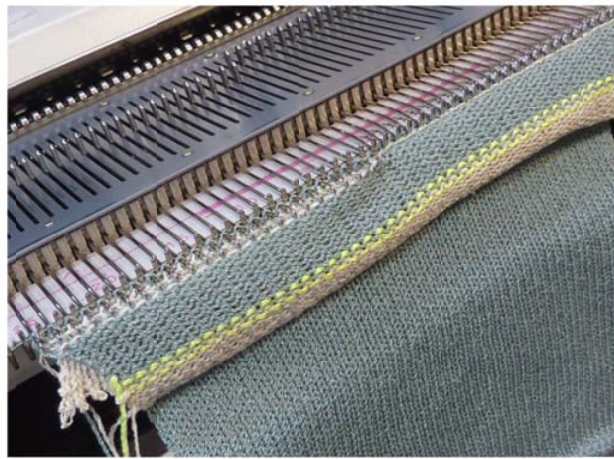
Push the stitches behind the latches





3. With the wrong (private) side facing, rehang the waistband stitches in the hooks of the needles.

Pull the waistband stitches through the garment stitches.



4. Knit the second half of the waistband

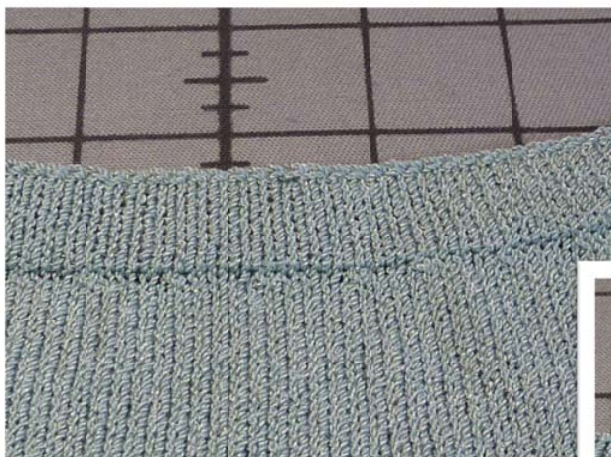
5. Pick up the first half of the waistband, fold back the waste yarn. Pickup and rehang the waistband stitches on the needles

Bind off LOOSELY

For an invisible band, consider working a Kitchener Stitch seam, joining the 2 band edges. This eliminates any worry about binding off loosely. Plus, it is beautiful!



When you remove all the waste yarn, you will see your two piece waistband that is beautiful both inside and outside!



Watch this technique in action.

View the Knit it Now tutorial
[“Designer Waistbands”](#)

Basic Hems

A beautiful hem can make or break the appearance of your skirt. Knitting the perfect hem involves a number of steps.

Basic Hems

Knit your skirt from the hem up with a basic hem

Stop!

Unlike woven fabric, knitted fabric tends to curl, simply turning up a hem will not give a satisfactory finish to your skirt.

1. Cast on
2. Knit $\frac{1}{2}$ the hem
3. Knit a turning row
4. Knit $\frac{1}{2}$ the hem
5. Hang the hem
6. Knit your garment



Step 1: Three cast on methods

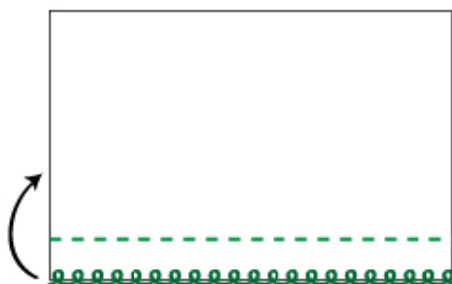
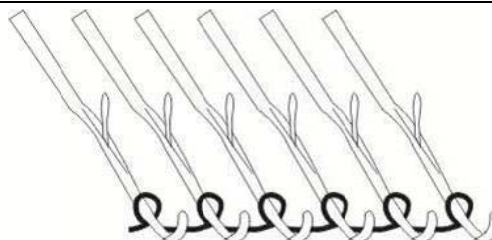
Different cast on methods will give different result for your hem

- E-wrap cast on
- Waste yarn and ravel cord cast on
- Every other needle Cast on

E-Wrap Cast On

Start your skirt piece with a simple, loose e-wrap cast on.

This is a fast cast on that looks great on the private side of the work.

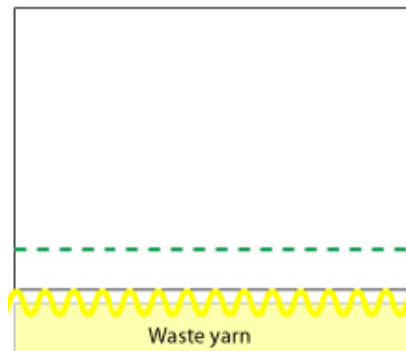


Waste yarn and ravel cord cast on

Start your skirt with waste yarn and ravel cord, then hang your hem from the live stitches.

Remove the waste yarn when the garment piece is completed.

Some knitters prefer this method because it eliminates the extra strand from an e-wrap cast on.



Top: Scrap and Ravel hung hem

The difference between the 2 methods is very subtle

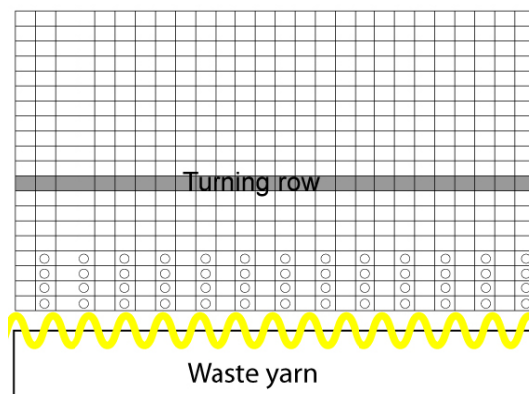
Bottom: E-wrap cast on hung hem

Every other needle cast on

Using either waste yarn or e-wrap methods, cast on every other needle.

Knit for a few rows (1/2 the hem depth) over every other needle, then put all needles into work and knit the remainder of the hem over every needle.

This provides a much smoother hem join.



Left: Every other needle cast on shows reduced bulk

Right: Every needle in work



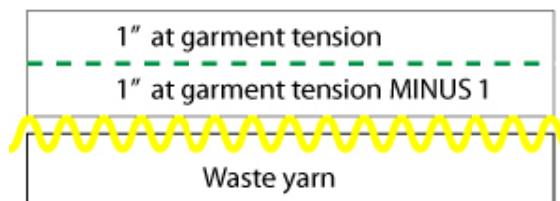
Steps 2-3-4: Knit the Hem

Tension

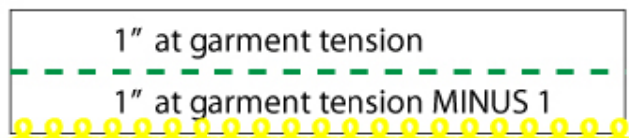
The secret to a perfect hem involves remembering that knitting tends to curl.

Knit the private (wrong side) half of the hem at a tighter tension than your garment tension

Waste yarn cast on



E-wrap cast on



Turning Row

For a beautiful hem, create a defined edge with a turning row

1. Knit one row at a large tension



2. Knit a garter ridge

Remove the work on a garter bar, turn and rehang. Knit 1 row. Remove and turn again. Continue knitting.



3. Knit a picot edge

Transfer every other needle to create eyelets. Keep emptied needles in work and complete the hem.



	10	9	8	7	6	5	4	3	2	1	
2											
1	○	⧻	○	⧻	○	⧻	○	⧻	○	⧻	1

Legend:

- ☒ Transfer Right (2 sts on 1 needle)
- ☒ Eyelet
- ☐ knit

Knit It Now

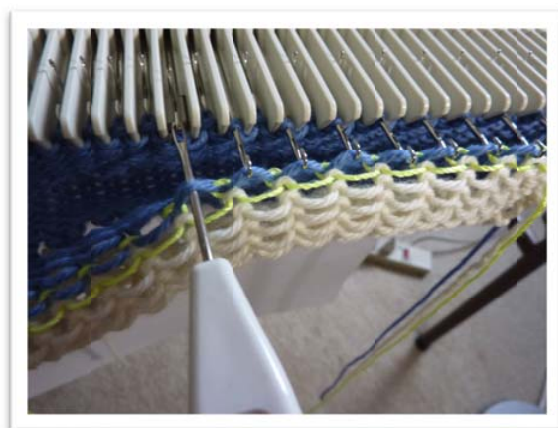
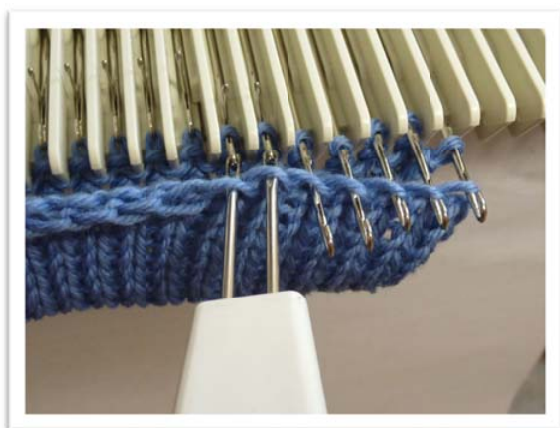
Step 5: Hang the hem

Hang your cast on edge to form the hem. If you used waste yarn and ravel cord for your cast on, be sure to pick up every live stitch.

To be sure that they've picked up every stitch, some knitters will carefully remove the waste yarn before knitting the joining row.

Once the hem pocket is formed and all stitches have been re-hung, knit 1 row at a looser tension to join the hem.

Don't forget to change back to garment tension! Finish knitting your skirt.



Designer Hem Secrets

Here are 2 secrets for hems that will never flare or curl. They take a bit more time ... but are well worth it!

Secret #1 – reduce the hem width

Secret #2 – Reduce the tension

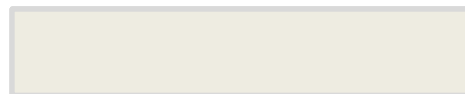
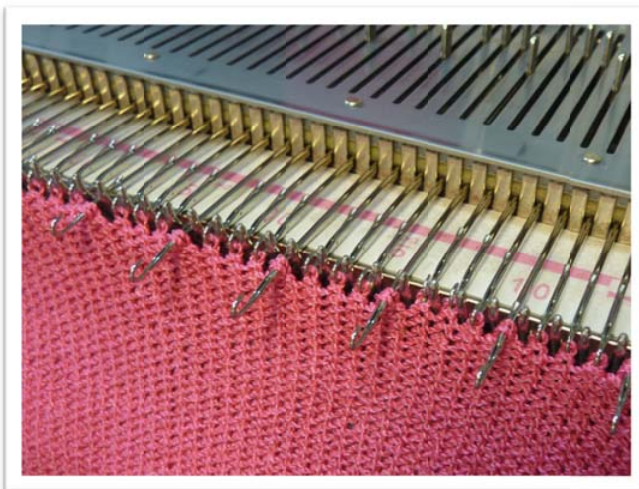
Secret #1

Reduce the hem width so it will not flare.

1. Start your skirt piece with waste yarn and ravel cord. Knit all your skirt pieces before working the hems.
2. Re-hang the hem edge on the machine, reducing the number of stitches by 15% to 25%.

For a 25% decrease double up every 4th stitch when re-hanging your garment. For less reduction hang every 5th or 6th stitch.

3. Knit 1 row at garment tension to eliminate the doubled stitches.



4. Knit a marker row by slipping every other stitch on the next row



Watch this technique in action.

View the Knit it Now tutorial
[“Perfect Designer Hems”](#)



Secret #2

5. Reduce your tension. Test this with your yarn, but knitting the entire hem at a tighter tension than garment tension will also keep the hem from flaring and curling. If possible, try knitting the entire hem at a full number tighter than the garment tension
6. Hang your hem from your marker row
7. Bind off



Straight off the machine, the skirt will look gathered, but once it is blocked, the hem will be flat and it will not curl or flare.



Yarn Choices, Tension and Stitch Patterns

Skirts can be knit in any yarn. Unlike sweaters, skirts take much more abuse from sitting. The properties of the yarn you select, the stitch pattern you choose and the knitting tension play a large role in having a skirt that holds its shape and one that will “seat out” and look sloppy after a few hours.

YARN

The most common yarn for skirts is a blend of wool and rayon (or wool and nylon). This long-wearing, hard-twist dress yarn has been popular for a very long time. It has had many names over the years, Velveen, Venetia, Wool Ray, Cravenella, Wool Crepe Deluxe.

The wool content provides a natural fiber that breathes; the rayon contributes strength and drape. The blend produces a fabric that is wrinkle resistant and one that holds its shape. Used by high-end clothing manufacturers, this is the recommended yarn for skirts (especially form-fitting pencil skirts).

Another popular hard twist dress yarn on cones is Tamm Diamante. It is a blend of Acrylic and Poly and is economical.

Other hard twist, dress yarns are available in both man-made fibers and blends. The decision about yarn depends on your budget and preferences for fibers.



[Wool Crepe Deluxe](#), [Diamante](#) and other skirt yarns are available from Knit it Now.

TENSION

To prevent “seating” you will want to knit your skirts at the tightest tension possible for your yarn. How tight? That depends on your machine and your yarn. Before knitting your gauge swatch, Knit a tension swatch to determine how your machine knits your yarn.

To knit a tension swatch:

The following is an example. Use the tensions appropriate for your machine and yarn.

1. Cast on and knit a few rows at tension 5
observe how the carriage moves and that the stitches form correctly
2. Reduce the tension by 1 dot and knit for 1” – 2”
continue to watch your knitting closely
3. Repeat until you notice a drag on the carriage. If it’s hard for you to push the carriage, it’s hard for the machine to form the stitches correctly.
4. When the tension is too tight, the stitches will not form. Notice the loops around the gate pegs, and over the needle hooks.
5. Loosen up your tension, and record the setting for your gauge swatch. If individual stitches continue to be mis-formed when knitting your gauge swatch, loosen up a bit more.

Some knitters will use wax or yarn spray to help when knitting at a tight tension. If your yarn is “aged” and dry, this might help. If your yarn is aged or dry ... do you really want to invest the time in knitting your skirt?

Knitting at too tight a tension will cause the stitches to mis-form and loop

A word about speed knitting

When we knit swatches, we tend to knit very quickly. When knitting across 200 needles, we establish a different knitting rhythm.

This can cause a difference in gauge between your swatch and your finished piece.

When knitting swatches make a conscious effort to slow down and replicate the speed that you will be knitting your garment.



STITCH PATTERNS

Stockinette

For a classic look, knit your skirt in plain stockinette stitch.

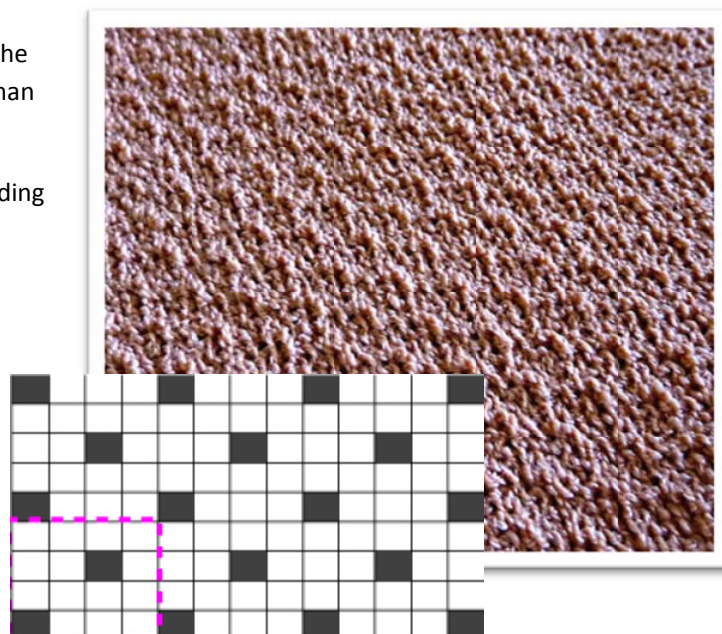


For additional texture, make the purl side the public side and knit a stockinette hem for contrast.

Tuck

If you need more width across 200 needles than stockinette can provide, tuck may be the answer. Tuck stitch fabric is usually wider than stockinette

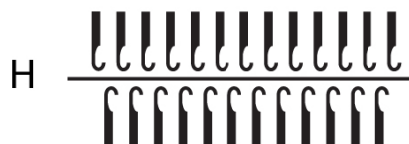
Program your machine for a 1 row tuck. Adding a simple tuck to your skirt fabric will give a subtle texture and additional width.



Full Needle Rib

For a luxurious skirt that will resist wrinkles and hold its shape, consider using full needle rib. This will create a comfortable, durable fabric with much more body than plain stockinette. Because of the density of the fabric, the skirt will fall away from the body.

Depending on the ease included when you draft your pattern, full needle rib fabric will not be as body-hugging. Skirts designed with zero ease in addition to the natural stretch of full needle rib, your skirt can be as shapely as you like!



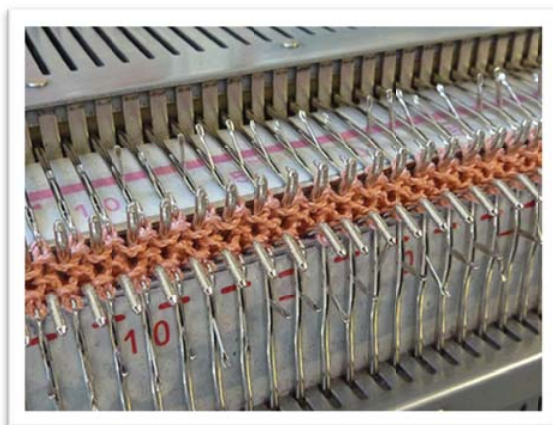
Long Stitch

A variation of full needle rib is Long Stitch. To create Long Stitch, set your ribber for full needle rib.

Then set your ribber carriage to slip in one direction. This creates elongated stitches on the rib side of the fabric for a different look.



Full Needle Rib: All stitches are being knit. Notice the zig zag between the beds



Long Stitch: Slip in one direction – the needles on the main bed knit, but the needles on the ribber did not. Notice there is no zig zag between the beds.

Top: Full Needle Rib

Bottom: Long Stitch

The lower section of the photo is long stitch and the upper section is full needle rib.

Although it is difficult to see in the photo, try this technique yourself and you will see what a lovely fabric long stitch creates.



Slits

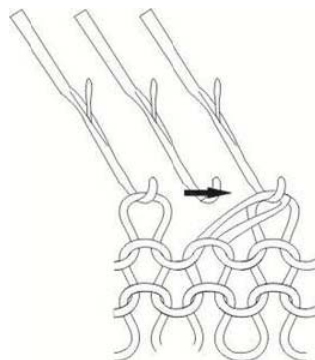
Adding a slit to a slim pencil skirt adds style and comfort. Traditionally, a slit is placed at the center back, but you can choose to add this opening in any seam.

Plan ahead when designing your skirt so you can work a finished edge as you knit your pieces.



Easy Lace Edge

1. Transfer the second stitch from the edge to the first stitch. Leave the emptied needle in work.
2. Knit 2 rows
3. Repeat for the entire slit opening
4. Press flat



Easy Lace Edge #2

4 needle repeat

1. Carriage on the right, transfer stitches as in chart (transfer left: stitch 3 to 4)
2. Knit 2 rows
3. Carriage on the right, transfer stitches as in chart (transfer right: stitch 4 to 3)
4. Repeat for length of the opening

Note that the 2 edge stitches knit evenly throughout the trim and naturally roll.

Leave emptied needles in working position throughout the trim

8					
	↘	○			7
6					
	○	↘			5
4					
	↘	○			3
2					
	○	↘			1



Knit



Eyelet



Transfer Left (2 sts on 1 needle)



Transfer Right (2 sts on 1 needle)



Watch this technique in action.



View the Knit it Now tutorial

[“Edges for Slit Skirts”](#)

If you decide to add a slit after the knitting is finished, here are 2 options

Afterthought Finish - Crochet

Work a row of single crochet or crab stitch (reverse single crochet) along the edges of your slit. A contrasting color may be just the finish your skirt needs.



Machine Knit Afterthought Finish

Sew up the seams of your skirt to the point of your slit

With the wrong (private) side facing, open the work and hang the edges on the machine

Be sure to hang the same number of stitches on each side of the slit.



Remember you are knitting stitches to rows. Hang 3 stitches to every 4 rows or so. You don't want to stretch the slit opening.



Try hanging the inside loop of the outside stitch for less bulk

Knit 1 row from left to right

Bind off all the stitches



Note: Work your edge finish on the public side of the hem only. (Don't try to pick up both sides of the folded hem.)

When the slit finishing is complete, neatly whip stitch the inside portion of the hem in place.



Measuring

Ease

Ease is the difference between the actual body measurement and the finished measurement of your skirt.



Measure: (with ease)

Waist _____
 Hip at fullest point _____
 Waist to fullest point _____
 Waist to finished length _____

Keep ease in mind when measuring
 for your skirt



Tip:

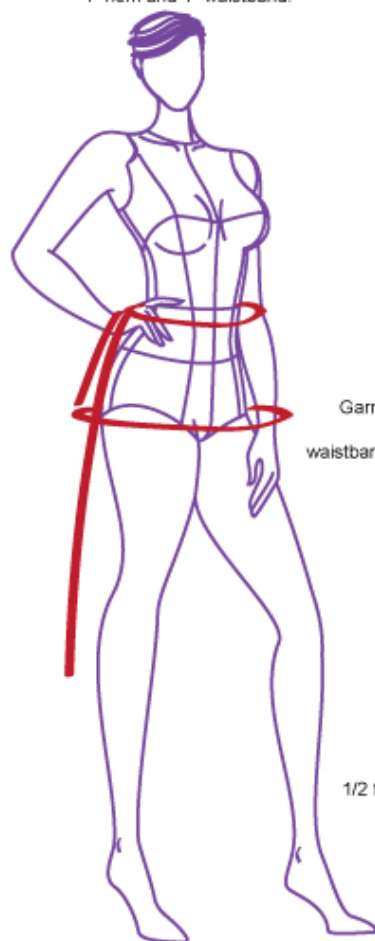
To add extra ease and prevent your skirt from cupping in the rear, hold a magazine against the tummy and measure the hip.



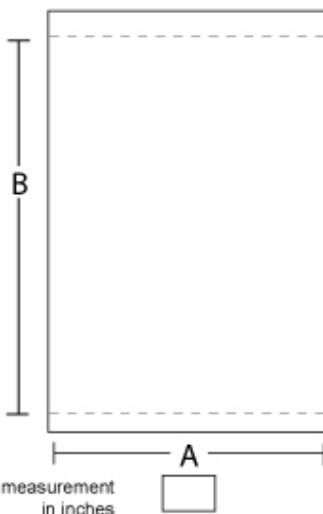
Chart Your Own Pattern

BASIC PENCIL SKIRT

Simple, easy-to-knit 2 gore pencil skirt with no shaping and 1" hem and 1" waistband.



Garment length
MINUS
waistband and hem
in inches



1/2 finished hip measurement
in inches

	Stitches per inch
	Rows per inch

KNIT 2

Cast on {A x stitches per inch} _____ Stitches

Knit for 1" _____ rows

Knit a turning row

Knit for 1" _____ rows

Hang hem

Knit for {B x row per inch} _____ Rows

Knit a marker row

Knit 1" _____ rows

Knit a turning row

Knit 1" _____ rows

Pick up from marker row

Bind off loosely

The Perfect Pencil Skirt

- Knit your pieces with as many [gores](#) as you like.
- Start at the waist with waste yarn and ravel cord and end at the hem with waste yarn.
- Add waist shaping. Use the Magic Formula, knitters graph paper, DesignaKnit or the [Knit it Now Taper Tool](#) to calculate the shaping.
- Add a side slit, (modest or daring) for style and comfort
- Block your pieces.
- Rehang your hem with the [Designer Hem Secrets](#).
- Rehang the top of the skirt from the waste yarn and work a [Couture Waistband](#)
- Carefully seam your pieces and block the seams
- Insert elastic
- **Enjoy!**

